

Free checklist

The CTO Readiness Checklist *twenty questions, twenty minutes.*

Every founder should be able to answer these about their own technology. Tick the ones you can. The gaps are where a CTO earns their keep.

How to use this

Go through the twenty questions honestly. For each one, tick *Yes* if you could answer it today without asking anyone, *Partly* if you have a rough idea, and *No* if you would have to go and find out. Scoring is at the end.

☐ Yes ☐ Partly ☐ No

Strategy and direction

01 Can you explain, in two sentences, what your technology needs to do in the next twelve months? ☐ ☐ ☐

If the plan lives only in one developer's head, it is not a plan.

02 Do you know which parts of your product you should build and which you should buy? ☐ ☐ ☐

Most early teams build things a vendor would sell them for the price of a lunch.

03 Do you know what your technology costs per month, per customer? ☐ ☐ ☐

Cloud, licences, contractors, tools. If the number is a guess, so is your margin.

04 Could you tell an investor or buyer what technical debt you carry and what it would cost to clear? ☐ ☐ ☐

Every diligence process asks. The good answer is a short list, not a shrug.

05 Is there a written record of the big technical decisions and why they were made? ☐ ☐ ☐

Not documentation of everything. Just the choices that would be expensive to reverse.

People and delivery

06 If your lead developer resigned tomorrow, could someone else ship a change within a week? ☐ ☐ ☐

This is the single most common risk in a small technical team.

07 Do you know how long it takes from deciding on a change to customers using it? ☐ ☐ ☐

Days is healthy. Months means something is broken in the process, not the people.

08 Are you confident you are paying your developers and agencies the right amount for what you get? ☐ ☐ ☐

Not the cheapest. The right amount.

09 Do you know who you need to hire next, and could you tell a good candidate from a fluent one? ☐ ☐ ☐

Technical interviews are where non-technical founders get burned most often.

10 Does your team get a clear priority list, or do they get whichever request arrived last? ☐ ☐ ☐

Ask them. The answer is often not what the founder thinks.

Platform and risk

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- 11 **Do you own every account your business runs on: domain, cloud, source code, app stores, payments?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- If any of these are in a contractor's name, fix that this week.
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- 12 **If your main system went down on a Monday morning, do you know who would be called and what they would do?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- An incident plan on one page beats none at all.
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- 13 **Are backups taken, and has anyone ever actually restored from one?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- An untested backup is a hope, not a backup.
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- 14 **Do you know where your customer data lives and who can access it?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- This is the question a privacy complaint or a large customer's security team will ask first.
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- 15 **Does every person who has left the business still have access to anything?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- Check. It is almost always yes.
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Product and growth

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- 16 **Do you know which features customers actually use, from data rather than from feel?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- Half of most products goes untouched. Knowing which half changes what you build next.
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- 17 **Could your systems handle ten times the customers without a rebuild?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- You do not need to be ready for it today. You need to know what would break first.
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- 18 **Have you looked at where AI or automation would remove real work from your team's week?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- Not a chatbot on the website. The manual, repeated, error-prone work inside the business.
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- 19 **Do you have a way to test an idea with customers before committing a build budget to it?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- A prototype, a mock-up, a landing page. Anything cheaper than the real thing.
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- 20 **Do you have someone senior to talk to before you make a technical decision you cannot easily undo?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- If the answer is no, that is the gap this checklist exists to point at.
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Scoring

16 to 20 Yes. You are in better shape than most. You probably do not need anyone on retainer. A technical audit every twelve months is a cheap way to be sure the picture is still accurate.

10 to 15 Yes. Common for a growing business, and every gap on this list is fixable. This is what the subscription is for: send the decisions as they come up and get them handled, one at a time, for one flat monthly fee.

Under 10 Yes. You are carrying more risk than you can see, and guessing at which risk to fix first is expensive. Start with a technical audit so you know exactly what you are dealing with, then decide what kind of help you need.

Want a second opinion on your answers?

Book a fifteen-minute call. No slides and no pitch, just a clearer picture of where your technology stands. thefractionalcfo.au